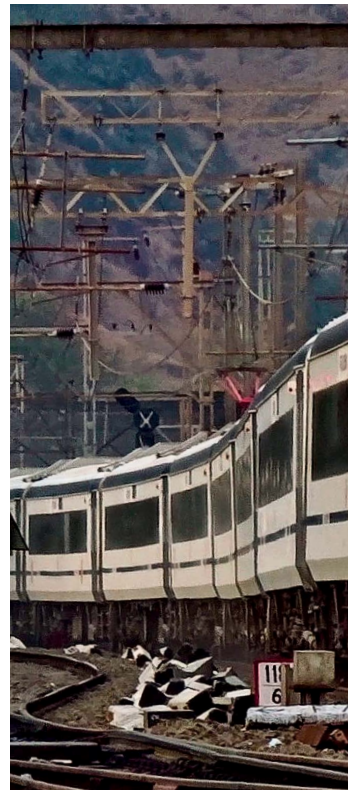


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A BIG UPGRADE Unlike local trains, the Vande Bharat trains will offer uniform seating and efficient LED lighting in coaches

| URBAN MOBILITY |

VANDE MUMBAI!

The Indian Railways' flagship train is expected to redefine urban rail transportation in India's commercial capital

BY MANISH PANT

► **MENTION THE MUMBAI LOCAL** and the images that come to mind are of an urban rail transportation system that is efficient and functional, yet during peak hours can be packed to the hilt, hot, dirty, and dangerous. So, by the journey's end, one often ends up feeling like a crushed *vada pav*. On the other hand, mention Vande Bharat and the Indian Railways' flagship semi-high-speed passenger train conjures up images of comfort, cleanliness and a safe travel experience. Although the Mumbai local may be Mumbai local

and Vande Bharat may be Vande Bharat, the two are set to meet in the not-too-distant future to create what is expected to be a sublime travel experience for Mumbai's 22.9 million denizens.

On May 19, when the Railway Board approved the procurement of 238 Vande Bharat rakes to serve on the 158-year-old Mumbai suburban rail network, it caused a flutter. The locals are going to be completely overhauled under the Mumbai Urban Transport Project (MUTP). The rakes will be acquired under the

MUTP-3 and MUTP-3A phases with budgets of ₹10,947 crore and ₹33,960 crore, respectively. This will be overseen by the Ministry of Railways and the Maharashtra government. *Business Today* learns that work on tendering is already underway. "Timelines will be drawn soon as the tender documents are ready," inform officials of the executing agency, Mumbai Rail Vikas Corp. (MRVC).

Forty-seven rakes of 12 cars each will be acquired under MUTP-3 and the rest in the MUTP-3A phase. "This is initial sanction obtained